

Αἰσώπου Βίος-ἄνωνυμος

Slave, Sage, and Fabulist in the Life of Aesop

eul_aid: pqy

Period: Ῥωμαϊκή [Roman](#)
Dialect: Κοινή [Koine](#)
Domain: Μυθιστορία [Fiction](#)
Format: Πεζός [Prose](#)

Life

The Life of Aesop, also known as the Aesop Romance, is an anonymous fictional biography composed in Greek prose during the 1st or 2nd century CE. It blends folk-tale, satire, and novelistic elements to present Aesop as an ugly, initially mute slave who gains speech from the goddess Isis. His story recounts his clever outwitting of masters and philosophers, culminating in his unjust execution at Delphi, within an anachronistic setting reflecting the Roman Imperial era.

Works

The work is a single, unified narrative. The principal surviving versions are the longer "G" recension and a shorter "W" version. Some analyses divide the narrative into five major episodic blocks, such as his servitude under the philosopher Xanthus and his journey to Delphi.

Significance

The Life of Aesop is a crucial precursor to the Greek novel and a key text for understanding ancient popular culture and prose fiction. Its portrayal of a subversive, cunning slave-hero provides a valuable window into social critique in the Roman Empire. The work was widely influential, translated into multiple languages, and its motifs impacted later literature like the Life of Secundus.

Works (5)

- Βιβλίον μυθικὸν τοῦ Αἰσώπου · [Aesop's Mythical Book](#) · 2 passages
- Βίος Γ · [Life G](#) · 137 passages
- Βίος Αἰσώπου · [Life of Aesop](#) · 3 passages
- Βίος Αἰσώπου Πλ ἢ Ἀκκουρσιανός · [Life of Aesop Pl or Accursiana](#) · 80 passages
- Βίος · [Life W](#) · 138 passages